

ÒDÈ-ÌKÁ

Written by CENProject and Babalawo Ajetumobi Esubiyi
Obakolawole

Based on Odu Ifa Ìká Méjì

A Yoruba-language Epic Feature Film
Produced at the intersection of Ifa, Art, Science & Game

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FADE IN:

ACT ONE – ÌBÈ`RÈ` (THE FRONTIER)

EXT. THE FRONTIER – DARKNESS – BEFORE DAWN

Darkness. Complete. Total. The world before seeing.

Then – a voice. Old. Measured. Unhurried. It speaks in Yoruba. English subtitles appear below, clean and white.

VOICE (V.O.)

(in Yoruba)

Mo de Òde Ìká –

[SUBTITLE: I arrive at the Frontier of Ìká –]

On the word: a vast frontier landscape materializes from darkness. Ancient city walls seen from outside – massive, layered, inscribed. We are arriving somewhere formidable. The walls pulse faintly with a light that is not fire.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Òde Ìkà –

[SUBTITLE: The Frontier of Cruelty –]

FLASH: the same city walls, now seen through a lens of violence – the stone edges sharper, the shadows deeper. Same city. Different perception.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Òde Àká –

[SUBTITLE: The Frontier of the Woven Thread –]

FLASH: the same walls, now seen through threads – looms visible everywhere, cloth patterns woven into the stone itself.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Òde Ònkà –

[SUBTITLE: The Frontier of Counting –]

FLASH: the same city, now numerical – the walls covered in marks, patterns, configurations. Mathematics in the architecture.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Níbití orúkọ wọn rí kakaka –

[SUBTITLE: Where their names are many-layered and intricate –]

Names appear on the city walls: carved, chalked, woven, pressed into clay, painted in indigo. Dozens of names. Hundreds. Layered atop each other. A palimpsest of identities.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Tí ọba wọn ní'gbé ní káà –

[SUBTITLE: Where their king dwells within the innermost chamber –]

A king – seen from a great distance, from outside a system of chambered walls. Each wall opens to reveal another wall behind it. He is at the center. We cannot see his face. He is deep inside something we have not yet earned the right to see.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Tí o ní'dáfá pẹ̀lú orí ọkà –

[SUBTITLE: Who casts divination with the head of the cobra snake –]

A divination tray – the circular Ifa tray, dusted with Iyerosun powder. Hands we do not yet recognize tracing marks across the powder with what appears to be a bone – dry, precise. The cobra's severed head. A tool, not a trophy.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Tí ìbakà talákáa léjìká –

[SUBTITLE: Where the donkey struck the man named Lákáa upon the shoulder –]

FLASH: a large gray donkey. A man falling. We don't understand yet. We are not meant to. The image is there and then gone.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Àkàakà ìgbasà ló jẹ' ará Òde Ìká –

[SUBTITLE: The ones that spun the thread continuously in the ìgbasà tree are the people of Òde Ìká –]

Women at the base of a vast, ancient tree – the ìgbasà. Their hands spinning thread without stopping, without looking at their hands. Thread that goes upward into the tree's canopy and disappears. They have been doing this longer than anyone living can remember.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Lọba ọba wọn, Oníkàámògún, ní'tayò Oníkàà –

[SUBTITLE: Their paramount king, Oníkàámògún, plays the chambered-Ayo Game –]

An Ayo game board – not the standard twelve-pit board. Sixteen pots, arranged in two facing rows. Seeds moving. The board glows faintly, as if it holds light inside each chamber. A hand moves seeds. We cannot see the face above the hand.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Ọ̀ta ló máa jẹ Oníìká –

[SUBTITLE: It is the winner who will be crowned as king of Ìká –]

A figure receives something – not a crown. An understanding. We cannot see his face either. Both the giver and receiver remain unknown to us. For now.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Tí o mamaa jayé ọba ní káà –

[SUBTITLE: Yet he is the one who will always thrive and reign as king within the chamber –]

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Òde Ìká níbití wọn tí n'se aṣọ àká –

[SUBTITLE: Òde Ìká, where they have long been weaving the àká cloth –]

The àká cloth being woven. The geometric patterns forming under a weaver's hands – complex, layered, mathematical.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Tí èbìtì kakaka nípa ìgbín kakaka –

[SUBTITLE: Where the strong trap kills the strong snail –]

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Nítorì èbìtì tí ò gbójú kòlè pàgbín kakaka –

[SUBTITLE: Because a trap that is not strong cannot kill the strong snail –]

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Nílú Òde Ìká tí wọn tí n'se aṣọ àká –

[SUBTITLE: In the city of Òde Ìká, where they have long been weaving the àká cloth.]

We are inside Òde Ìká now. We have seen everything. We understand nothing. Yet.

The poem ends. The film begins.

INT. INSTITUTE OF IFA STUDIES, LECTURE HALL – DAY

A space that is both a university lecture hall and a sacred compound. Rows of Ifa scholars – Babalawo, Iyanifa, Onisese, Olorisa – who are simultaneously professors, scientists, engineers, architects. The walls hold Odu notation and molecular diagrams in the same frame.

At the front: ỌLÁBERINJỌ, 40s, lean and deliberate. He moves like someone who has thought about every room he has walked into. He is presenting, but "presenting" is not quite right – he is wrestling, in public.

Projected behind him: a diagram of fields of knowledge, all separated, labeled, boxed. Mathematics. Physics. Medicine. Literature. Music. Philosophy. Each in its own compartment. No lines between them.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

We have built the most comprehensive knowledge infrastructure in the history of this civilization. Every discipline represented. Every school of thought accessible. We have, by every objective measure, everything.

(pause)

And still the students tell me they feel as if they have nothing. The engineers cannot read nature. The artists cannot derive principles. The mathematicians cannot hear the music in the equations. They trade knowledge upon knowledge and call themselves poor.

He gestures to the diagram of separated fields.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ (CONT'D)

We have organized knowledge into separate rooms and forgotten that knowledge does not live in rooms. We pass through these rooms without

rooting in any of them. We are –
 Ọlọ̀gbẹ̀rì. The uninformed.

A murmur in the hall. The word lands.

At the center of the council of elders sits ÌYÁ AKÁỌGBỌ̀N
 – ancient, precise, wearing the àká-woven cloth of her
 order. She has heard everything he's said and found it
 both correct and insufficient.

ÌYÁ AKÁỌGBỌ̀N

(in Yoruba)

Ìwúre tó pé kì í padà òfo. A
 well-formed question always finds its
 answer. You have asked the right
 question.

[SUBTITLE: A prayer that is complete
 is never wasted. A well-formed
 question always finds its answer. You
 have asked the right question.]

(beat)

Wá Oníkàámògún.

[SUBTITLE: Find Oníkàámògún.]

The hall goes quiet.

Ọláberinjọ stands very still. He knows this name. He has
 studied this name. He has never expected to hear it spoken
 as a practical instruction.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

(quietly)

Where?

ÌYÁ AKÁỌGBỌ̀N

Bẹ̀rẹ̀.

[SUBTITLE: Begin.]

The diagram on the wall behind Ọláberinjọ – all those
 separated fields – begins to blur. The compartments lose
 their edges. The image dissolves.

We go deep into the ancient layer.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT./INT. ÒDÈ ÌKÁ – DAY (MYTHIC-ANCIENT)

Ọláberinjọ stands at the entrance to Òde Ìká – experiencing this as a divination journey: he is simultaneously observer and participant.

The city is alive. Not the civilization-as-backdrop of lesser epics – alive in the specific sense: weavers at looms in open compounds, diviners casting in courtyards while children watch, Ayo games being played at every corner. Craftspeople who work with the precision of scientists and the beauty of artists, because in Òde Ìká these are the same thing.

The city smells of àká cloth and fresh iyerosun powder and akara frying somewhere nearby.

The four DIVINER-WITNESSES materialize beside him – present as elders who both narrate and inhabit this world.

ẸẸ'MỌ'NÍKÁ

(to Ọláberinjọ)

Ẹ káàbọ̀ sí Òde Ìká.

[SUBTITLE: Welcome to Òde Ìká.]

ÀJÀNÀMỌKÁ

The city where everything has more than one name, because everything here is more than one thing.

In the market quarter: ALÁKÀRÀ stands with her tray of akara – perfect, golden, fragrant. The market moves around her in all directions. Nobody stops. Nobody buys. She stands as if the market is happening in a different world from the one she occupies.

ALÁKÀRÀ

(to no one, to everyone)

Wọn kò tún din àkàrà mọ` nibi.

[SUBTITLE: They no longer fry akara here.]

Ọláberinjọ watches her. He wants to say: you are frying akara right now. But he understands that this would not be the right response to what he is witnessing.

ARÁ Ọ`FÀ

(quietly, to
Ọláberinjọ)

Her akara is perfect. The market is full. She has everything she needs to trade. This is the crisis.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

What is the crisis, if not shortage?

ÒKÒKÒ

(the quiet one; speaks
only when necessary)

Perception. She cannot see what is already in her hands.

INT. ÒDÈ ÌKÁ, DIVINATION COURT – DAY

The four diviner-witnesses and Ọláberinjọ, in the city's central divination court. Open-roofed. Iyerosun powder marks on the stone floor. The sound of the city all around them.

ẸLẸ`MỌ`NÍKÁ

Before you begin, there is one thing you must hold. One sentence. If you forget it, the journey will break you. If you carry it, the journey will make you.

He speaks deliberately, each word a placed weight.

Ẹ̀LE' MỌ' NÍKÁ (CONT'D)

(in Yoruba)

Oníkà nínú ni ò ẹ̀ ẹ̀kà rí.

[SUBTITLE: The one who holds Ìkà within does not practice cruelty.]

The word hangs in the court.

Ọ̀LÁBERINJỌ

What is Ìkà, if not cruelty?

ÀJÀNÀMỌKÁ

That is the question the journey will answer.

The invocations begin – not prayers. Calibrations.

ALL FOUR DIVINERS

(together)

Káwọ́'mi –

[SUBTITLE: Come to me –]

The sound of the city seems to lean toward Ọ̀láberinjọ.

ALL FOUR DIVINERS (CONT'D)

Káse`mi –

[SUBTITLE: Let me receive –]

Something opens in Ọ̀láberinjọ. Not a mystical event – a cognitive event. The quality of his attention changes. He is being tuned to a frequency he has not yet learned to hear.

INT. Ọ̀DÈ ÌKÁ, DIVINATION COURT – CONTINUOUS

Órunmilà's PRESENCE – not a figure, but an authority in the room. A weight. A direction.

ÓRUNMILÀ (V.O.)

(a voice that comes
from the direction of
the marks)

Ó ní abájọ tí ayé wọ̀n fi rí kàmì kámi
kàmì bí ẹ̀ni tí ń'káşọ.

[SUBTITLE: Your world moves back and
forth – kàmì kámi kàmì. Like a weaver
counting cloth, who never finishes the
pattern.]

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

(struck by this)

What do we do?

ÓRUNMILÀ (V.O.)

Wá Oníkàámògún, ọ̀mọ akáwórókó inú
yẹmẹtu.

[SUBTITLE: Find Oníkàámògún, child of
the one who weaves from within the
earth's foundation.]

ÀJÀNÀMỌKÁ

(explaining the name
to Ọláberinjọ)

Oní-ìkà-a-mò-gun. The possessor of
Ìká's power – who knows it – and does
not deploy it to destroy. Not a saint.
A master. There is a difference.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

Where is he?

ẸLẸ'MỌ'NÍKÁ

He has been seen in sixteen different
places. He is everywhere and nowhere.
You must begin at the first house and
work through all sixteen. He will not
be in any of them. But you will need

every one of them before you can reach him.

Ọláberinjọ looks at the four diviner-witnesses. He looks at the city around him – its weavers, its diviners, its Ayo boards, its markets. He takes a breath.

He begins.

CUT TO:

ACT TWO – ÌRIN-ÀJỌ` (THE JOURNEY)

EXT./INT. HOUSE OF OGBE – DAWN

The city announces itself as light. Everything here – architecture, clothing, art – is white and luminous. The Ogbе mark (eight parallel vertical lines) is carved into every surface, casting clean shadows at every angle of the sun. Ọláberinjọ enters. An elder BABALAWO of Ogbе is waiting at the city's great eastern wall.

OGBE BABALAWO

(without turning
around)

Stand here. Watch.

Ọláberinjọ stands at the wall as sunrise begins. As the sun rises, the Ogbе marks cast shadows. The shadow patterns change precisely with the angle of light. The elder has been recording these patterns for forty years.

OGBE BABALAWO (CONT'D)

What do you see?

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

A solar observatory.

OGBE BABALAWO

And the mark itself? The eight lines?

OLÁBERINJỌ

(slowly)

A straight line is the path of light.
 The mark... is the physics. The
 divination mark and the optical law
 are the same object, written in
 different languages.

OGBE BABALAWO

Good. Now you may continue.

(pause)

Oníkàámògún was here two months ago.
 He stood at this wall from sunrise to
 sunset. He said nothing when he left.

CUT TO:**INT. HOUSE OF OYEKU – NIGHT**

Underground architecture – not caves but inverted towers,
 lit by bioluminescent plants. The city of endings, where
 death is studied with precision. A HEALER plays a dirge
 over a dying patient. The rhythm is slow, measured, exact.

OLÁBERINJỌ

(watching the
 patient's condition
 changing in response
 to the rhythm)

She's using the drum rhythm as a
 medical protocol.

HEALER

(still playing;
 doesn't look up)

The rhythm encodes the preparation
 interval for the bark compound.
 Specific sequence – specific
 biochemical timing. The music is the
 prescription. Was Oníkàámògún here?

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

(surprised by the
question)

I was going to ask you.

HEALER

He was here when his teacher died. He sat with the body for three days. He didn't play music. He listened to the silence between the rhythms. When he left, he said: "The silence is also part of the notation."

CUT TO:

INT. HOUSE OF IWORI, INNER COURTYARD – DAY

A city of wells and mirrors – architecture that spirals inward. An IWORI SCHOLAR shows Ọláberinjọ a vast divination cloth stretched across an entire wall. It is a map – of consciousness itself. Territories, roads, markets, weather patterns.

IWORI SCHOLAR

The Ifa divination system does not only predict the external world. It also maps the mind of the one who seeks. The 256 Odu are 256 fundamental states of consciousness and their interactions.

(pointing to a
specific region of the
map)

This is the Ọ̀gbẹ̀rì condition. Look – here it is, precisely mapped. "The state of passing through without receiving – movement without contact."

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

(staring at the map)

You're describing the crisis I came to solve. It's already here. In the map.

IWORI SCHOLAR

The Odu described it before you arrived. The map was waiting for the mapmaker to recognize himself in it.

CUT TO:

INT. HOUSE OF ODI, SCULPTOR'S COMPOUND – DAY

The city that goes downward – built into hillsides, root systems exposed everywhere in the architecture. A SCULPTOR finishing a piece: the exact interior of a seed's germination, rendered with the precision of a modern biologist. Impossible precision for the tools available. Yet here it is.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

How do you know what this looks like?
No eye can see inside a germinating seed.

SCULPTOR

(not looking up from
her work)

Èmi ò kílí n'gbẹ́' ohun tí mo n'wò. Ohun
tí ó n'şẹlẹ̀ nì mo n'gbẹ́'

[SUBTITLE: I don't carve what I see. I
carve what is happening.]

Ọláberinjọ stands with this sentence for a long time. He will carry it through every remaining house.

CUT TO:

INT. HOUSE OF IROSUN, LINEAGE ARCHIVE – DAY

Everything here faintly red – the Irosun powder stains everything. A LINEAGE KEEPER unrolls a vast map that

covers an entire compound wall. Nodes connected by threads – a genealogy.

She overlays a second map. A third. A fourth. River system. Trade routes. The spread of a medicinal plant. All four maps are structurally identical.

LINEAGE KEEPER

There is only one river. It runs through everything. We call it Ọ̀ṣun when it carries water. We call it blood when it carries life. We call it lineage when it carries memory. We call it trade when it carries goods. The name changes. The mathematics does not.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

(tracing Oníkàámògún
on the lineage map)

He is here.

LINEAGE KEEPER

He traced his line back seventeen generations. He stayed three days. When he left he said: "The red thread was never just family. It was always the proof."

CUT TO:

EXT./INT. HOUSE OF OWONRIN, ÌLÚ-ÌLÙ – NIGHT (RAINING)

The house of wind and electricity – nothing stays still here. Within Owonrin's kingdom: ÌLÚ-ÌLÙ, the City of Drum. The inhabitants speak entirely in Èdè Ìlú – Drum Language. No spoken words. Everything is beat, rhythm, tone, tempo.

A MASTER DRUMMER performs in the rain. His performance is a response to the storm – as the storm intensifies, the rhythm shifts; as it relents, the rhythm relents. The drummer and the storm are in conversation.

After – the master shows Ọláberinjọ the notation of the performance: a system of drum-marks on palm leaf.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

(studying the notation)

This is a weather record. You recorded the storm as you played it. But you played it during the storm. You were predicting what it would do.

MASTER DRUMMER

(in drum-language – the subtitles appear in the rhythm of his speech)

We learned from the storm. The storm taught us the notation. Now when a storm begins, we play its opening phrase – and the storm completes it.

(picks up the drum again; plays a sequence)

Pi. To sixty-four positions.

(another sequence)

The orbital calculation of our brightest star.

(a third)

The molecular structure of the àgbasà bark.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

Who taught you this?

MASTER DRUMMER

The drum did. We taught the drum first. Then the drum taught us back. That is Owonrin. You give and it returns – transformed.

CUT TO:

EXT. HOUSE OF OBARA, PALACE COMPOUND – DAY

Grand, warm, generous. Fire at the palace center radiates through channels in the city's roads, warming every compound. The city layout, seen from above, is the Obara Odu mark.

OBARA KING

The way fire distributes heat and the way royal authority should distribute resources follow the same mathematics. We did not derive the governance from the physics. We developed them together, each correcting the other. They are the same document.

(beat)

Every city in this region was built from an Odu mark. The Odu is the blueprint. All sixteen cities are sixteen experiments in the same question.

Ọláberinjọ looks at the city's layout with new eyes. Sixteen experiments. He is living inside the experiment.

CUT TO:

INT. HOUSE OF OKANRAN, SMITH'S COMPOUND – DAY

A city of precision and decision – narrow, vertical architecture. The sound of hammers on iron from every direction. A BLACKSMITH shows Ọláberinjọ two finished blades – identical in appearance.

BLACKSMITH

One will shatter at maximum impact.
One will hold. Tell me which is which.

Ọláberinjọ examines them. He cannot tell. She turns the blades flat-side toward him. Now he can see: each has a

different surface pattern hammered into it. Concentric arcs on one. A branching geometry on the other.

BLACKSMITH (CONT'D)

The concentric arc disperses force – this blade holds steady under pressure. The branching geometry concentrates force at the tip – maximum impact, decisive cut, shatters under lateral pressure.

(directly)

The aesthetic of the pattern is the physics. You can read the blade the way you read the Odu – the mark tells you what will happen.

Ọláberinjo turns the branching blade in his hands. He recognizes the pattern: it is a variant of the Ogbe mark, spreading into space. He has seen this before. The first house. The same geometry, a different substrate.

EXT. HOUSE OF OKANRAN, ÀKÁ (STORAGE BARN) – DAY

Ọláberinjo walking toward the àká – the indigenous storage barn at the city's edge – where Oníkàámògún was last seen, a week ago.

He hears the commotion before he sees it. He pushes through a gathering crowd.

LÁKÁÁ is on the ground. Young. Named for Okanran's sharpness. He had been sent to fetch stored timber from the àká – seasoned wood held there for the smithing fires.

The donkey ÌBAKÀ stands a few feet away. Still. One foreleg slightly raised. The animal does not understand what it has done.

What happened: Lákáá reached the àká. Ìbakà startled – for no apparent reason; the air shifted, or a bird landed, or nothing at all. The animal's body turned. Its shoulder connected with Lákáá's shoulder at the moment both were in motion toward each other. The geometry was wrong. The angle was wrong. Okanran does not negotiate angles.

Lákáa fell. He did not rise.

The COBRA – Ọká – which has lived at the base of this àká for as long as anyone remembers – drawn here, as cobras are, by the rodents that follow stored grain – is coiled now at the barn's foundation post. Motionless. Watching. As Ọláberinjọ watches, the cobra makes a sound – not a hiss, something lower and longer – that he has never heard from any animal.

The grief of Okanran is clean, precise, without false comfort. No one wails. Several people weep without sound.

Ọláberinjọ finds an ELDER standing apart from the crowd.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

(shaken)

Was this necessary?

OKANRAN ELDER

The àká had to be reached. The wood had to come. Lákáa carried both the task and its cost. That is Okanran – the moment of decisive contact does not arrive because we are ready. It arrives because it is time.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

That isn't an answer.

OKANRAN ELDER

No. It is the truth. Which is different from an answer. An answer would make it comprehensible.

(pause)

Oníkàámògún stood where you are standing, the last time someone died at this àká. He stood for a long time. When he left, he went to the surgeon's compound and watched them work for three days. He didn't say why.

Ọláberinjọ looks at the àká – the barn wall, the foundation, the stored wood still inside. The cobra is still watching.

He walks through the city gate. He does not speak for the rest of the day.

CUT TO:

EXT. HOUSE OF OGUNDA, FOREST ROAD – DAY

Iron and forest in symbiosis. A ROAD-BUILDER laying a new road that curves three times against what geometry suggests. Ọláberinjọ asks why.

ROAD-BUILDER

Look at the root patterns. These trees still know where the ancient river ran – dried two hundred years ago. Their roots still follow it. We follow the river. The water knows the land better than we do. Engineering from biological memory.

Above the gate at the road's end: carved in Ogunda's mark – "Ilẹ̀ ní'gbádùn ẹnì tó wọ̀ inú rẹ̀." The land delights in the one who enters into it. Oníkàámògún left these words here.

CUT TO:

INT. HOUSE OF OSA, PAINTER'S STUDIO – DAY

A city of reversals. An ARTIST shows Ọláberinjọ a series of abstract paintings – intensely geometric, high contrast. She flips a panel. The other side: a precise phase diagram, the scientific map of a geological transition.

OSA ARTIST

You see the earth move. I see the equation. Art can hold the moment

between states longer than science can
 – because science must choose one side
 or the other. Painting exists in the
 in-between.

(showing the oldest
 painting)

Three hundred years old. It depicts
 the moment a river reversed course.
 The geological record confirmed it
 sixty years ago. The painter studied
 that river every day for forty years.
 The painting came from that study.

CUT TO:

EXT./INT. HOUSE OF ÌKÁ – DAY

He knows it before he arrives. A different quality of
 light – and the smell of àkà cloth in sufficient
 quantities to change the atmosphere. Every surface
 covered: woven panels on walls, àkà cloth as roof
 overhangs, àkà cloth folded and stacked in every compound.
 The marks woven into the cloth are the Odu marks of all
 sixteen. He reads them as he walks through, like a
 library.

INT. HOUSE OF ÌKÁ, IFA ART COMPOUND – CONTINUOUS

An entire quarter devoted to Ifa Arts and Orisa Arts
 production – not a museum. A working space. Cloth weavers,
 Ifa mark-carvers, Orisa image-makers, bead-stringers, Ifa
 board makers, calabash engravers.

Each artist is simultaneously something else. The cloth
 weaver has mathematical notations pinned to her loom-post,
 checked against the pattern as she works. The Orisa
 image-maker produces a metallurgical record in the image's
 surface pattern. The bead-stringer's color sequences
 encode medicinal plant combinations.

A calabash engraver working on a large piece – the
 engraving dense and intricate. Òláberinjò studies it. It
 takes several minutes to recognize: it is the map of the
 sixteen houses. Precisely. All sixteen kingdoms, their

spatial relationships, the roads between them, the 17th marked at the convergence point.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

Who commissioned this map?

CALABASH ENGRAVER

(not looking up)

Oníkàámògún. He described every house from memory. Sat here four days. Corrected me three times.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

When?

CALABASH ENGRAVER

Three days ago.

Three days. Ọláberinjọ is almost running.

INT. HOUSE OF ÌKÁ, CENTRAL COURTYARD – CONTINUOUS

Two Ayo games in adjacent compounds – one standard twelve-pit board, one something Ọláberinjọ has not seen before.

SIXTEEN POTS. Two rows of eight, facing each other. The pots are deeper than standard – each one a distinct chamber, carved separately and assembled. The seeds: 256 total, starting distribution not symmetrical. A central channel between the rows. Narrow. Currently empty.

The two men playing this board are slow. Deliberate. They study the full board before each move. No rapid-fire speed. This looks, to Ọláberinjọ, like a different activity from Ayo.

An ELDER watching speaks to him without being asked.

ELDER OF ÌKÁ

Regular Ayo teaches you survival. How seeds move. How one force outlasts another. It is a complete teaching – do not dismiss it. It has been teaching for a thousand years.

(gesturing to the
16-pot board)

Ayò Ọlọ́pọ́nfá is a different question. Each of the sixteen pots is a domain of knowledge. The seeds are insights. When you move a seed from one pot to another, you model the transfer of understanding from one field to another. The question is not who captures the most – the question is whether you understand how all sixteen fields interact simultaneously. Whether you can read the whole board at once.

(beat)

The central channel receives only when the board achieves a state of integration. You cannot force seeds into it. Watch.

As the two players simultaneously reach a particular configuration – a seed appears in the central channel, as if drawn there.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

(watching the seed in
the channel)

This is not a game. This is a meta-model machine.

ELDER OF ÌKÁ

The Ifa Computer. Yes.

Ọláberinjọ is late leaving this house.

EXT. HOUSE OF ÌKÁ, CITY GATE – LATE AFTERNOON

A CLOTH WEAVER intercepts him as he reaches the gate. She stops directly in front of him.

ÌKÁ WEAVER

You are looking for Oníkàámògún.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

Yes.

ÌKÁ WEAVER

He was here three days ago. He asked about you. He described you – knew your name, your lineage, your work. He said: he will come through here. Tell him this.

(reciting carefully,
exactly)

"The weave is the answer. Tell him the weave is the answer. He will know when he sees the whole cloth, not just the threads."

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

(quietly)

He knew I was coming.

ÌKÁ WEAVER

He said the quest works in both directions. You are searching for him. He has been watching you arrive.

(pause)

He also said: do not hurry the last five houses. The hurrying was the problem before.

"Before." Ọláberinjọ stands at the gate for a long time. Then he continues. Slowly.

CUT TO:

INT. HOUSE OF OTURUPON, RECOVERY ARCHIVE – DAY

A city excavating itself – old foundations visible, studied, preserved. A SCHOLAR OF RECOVERY shows Ọláberinjọ a text recovered from two centuries of misreading: what was dismissed as mythology about a king who ate too much salt is, under Oturupon's analysis, a precise clinical case study of a sodium imbalance disorder – diagnosis, treatment, outcome, follow-up.

SCHOLAR OF RECOVERY

It was always a medical case study. It was misclassified as myth by people who could not read both registers simultaneously. The arts and the sciences were always the same document. The separation was imposed from outside.

(gesturing to a room
of recovered texts)

More than we can count. We have been recovering for six generations and we are still in the first layer.

CUT TO:

EXT. HOUSE OF OTURA, SKY OBSERVATORY – NIGHT

High-built, open-roofed architecture facing always upward. A SKY-WATCHER shows Ọláberinjọ a divination tray oriented toward the night sky – the Iyerosun marks in exact correspondence with the star positions.

SKY-WATCHER

The Odu Marks came down from the sky, ọ̀run. Babalawo reads the Odu based on this understanding. The marks came down. Ọrun is the source – the Odu are the projections.

(showing Ọláberinjọ
the recorded visit)
Oníkàámògún came when the sky showed
his own Odu. An Ìká configuration.
Oníìká came when the sky called his
name.

CUT TO:

EXT. HOUSE OF IRETE, ANCIENT TREE – DAY

The oldest city in the journey. Ancient trees wider than buildings. An ELDER takes Ọláberinjọ to a rock formation at the city's edge – the pattern of the rocks is the Irete Odu mark. Not carved by human hands. Formed by geology over thousands of years.

IRETE ELDER

This formation was here before humanity. Our ancestors found it, studied it – the Irete mark came from this rock. The Odu mark is the result of the deepest possible attention to a natural process.

(at the 800-year tree)
Oníkàámògún sat with this tree for a week. When he left, he said: "The tree already knows everything. We are here to learn the speed at which it speaks."

CUT TO:

EXT. HOUSE OF OSE, RIVERBANK – NIGHT

The most beautiful city of the journey – deliberate beauty everywhere. Its markets overflow. Its buildings are beautiful in ways that make the city cooler, direct water efficiently, create shade exactly where people gather. Aesthetic choices that are also engineering choices, inseparable.

But Ọláberinjọ is not seeing the beauty tonight. He sits at the river's edge as the sun goes down. He has been through fourteen houses.

He lays out his divination chain – the opele – on the earth beside him. He has not cast for himself since the journey began.

He casts.

The Odu: Ose.

He almost laughs. He is in Ose's house and the Odu gives him Ose. The Odu knows where it is. Or: the Odu always gives you what you are standing in the middle of.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

(to himself, the ese
verse surfacing from
memory)

Ìgbín kakaka. Èbìtì kakaka. Èbìtì tí ò
bá gbójú; kòle pàgbín kakaka.

[SUBTITLE: The strong snail. The
strong trap. A trap that is not strong
cannot kill a strong snail.]

He sits with this. The river moves.

He has been through fourteen houses. He has more knowledge than he has ever held. And he has been a weak trap: moving toward knowledge rather than becoming it. Studying the quest rather than living inside it. The Ọlọ̀gbẹ̀rì condition – he has been inside it this entire time.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ (CONT'D)

(seeing it clearly for
the first time)

I am Alákàrà. I have been standing in
the market with perfect akara,
surrounded by everything I need, and
calling myself poor.

He stays at the river's edge all night. He does not sleep. He does not cast again. He sits with the Odu Ose open and does nothing except be present in the house of abundance,

by the river that connects everything.

At some point, deep in the night, he understands something about Lákáa.

Lákáa was not a cost the quest extracted. Lákáa's death is inside Ọláberinjọ now, carried through every house since Eight. It is the weight that makes his steps heavier. It is also the thing that prevents him from rushing. Because of Lákáa, he cannot be entirely academic about this journey. Because of Lákáa, he knows the quest is real.

In the morning: he rises. He is not the same person who sat down.

Before leaving, he goes to the market. He finds a seller standing with something perfect in a busy market, with no buyers. He buys. She is surprised – overly grateful. He is the first buyer she has had today.

He walks toward the sixteenth house eating what he bought, and does not look back.

CUT TO:

EXT./INT. HOUSE OF OFUN – DAY

The quietest city of the journey – not smaller, but different in quality. Everywhere: things being completed. A cloth weaver tying off the last threads of a vast panel she has worked on for years. A builder laying the last stone of a new building with enormous care. In the debate court, a long case closing – both advocates making final statements in the respectful tones of people who have argued well and are ready to be done.

Completion here is the most active state.

OFUN KING

(without preamble)

You have been through fifteen houses.
Each gave you something specific.
Something that could not come from any
other house. What remains – the thing
all fifteen could not give you – what
is it?

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

(considering this
carefully; does not
answer quickly)

The integration. I have fifteen knowledges I understand separately. I have begun to see the connections between them. But I have not yet seen them as one thing. I have seen the threads. I have not seen the whole cloth.

OFUN KING

That is what Ofun is. The cloth becoming visible because the weaving is complete. The pattern only emerges at completion – not before. The weaver knows this. She does not stop every few rows to ask whether the design is correct. She completes. Then she looks.

(beat)

The seventeenth is not another house after the sixteen. The seventeenth is what the sixteenth produces when it finishes. Ofun does not point toward it – Ofun becomes it when it completes.

EXT. HOUSE OF OFUN, CITY BOUNDARY – CONTINUOUS

The king walks Ọláberinjọ to the city's edge. Ahead: not another city. A convergence point – a place where you can feel that all sixteen roads lead here, even though he came from only one direction.

OFUN KING

He is there. I cannot point more precisely because "there" is not a location. It is a convergence. All sixteen roads arrive there

simultaneously. You came from one direction – but when you arrive, you will feel the other fifteen roads arriving with you.

(looking at Ọláberinjọ directly)

Most people find something in one of the sixteen houses that satisfies them and stop there. That is not wrong – the sixteen houses are complete in themselves. But those who must reach the seventeenth cannot stop. You felt the incompleteness in every house. Did you not?

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

Yes.

OFUN KING

Then you were always going to arrive. The only question was what you would be when you got there.

The king goes back into his city to watch things complete. Ọláberinjọ looks at the road ahead. He walks forward.

CUT TO:

ACT THREE – MÉJÌ (THE 17TH HOUSE)

EXT. THE CONVERGENCE ROAD – DAY

The road from Ofun does not feel like the previous roads. The landscape is not different – same terrain, same vegetation – but the quality of attention it demands is different. He is not searching. He is walking toward something that is walking toward him.

At a certain point he stops thinking about where he is going. His feet continue.

He arrives.

EXT./INT. THE 17TH COMPOUND – DAY

Not a building. A convergence of paths – sixteen roads meeting at a point, but the meeting is not a crossroads. It is a center of gravity. Each road does not end here; it turns inward here, spiraling gently into a clearing.

At the center of the clearing: a compound. Simple, clean, without decoration – all the decoration has been earned by the journey to reach it. The compound does not need ornament. It is already everything.

INT. THE 17TH COMPOUND, INNER COURTYARD – CONTINUOUS

And here:

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN.

He is exactly as the Opening Poem described. Exactly. We recognize him image by image.

The àkà cloth covers him from shoulder to ankle. Worn – not ragged, but worked. Lived in. This is not a ceremonial garment. It is his skin.

The cobra's head is in his right hand – dry, precise – tracing marks in the Iyerosun powder on the divination tray. The marks are unlike any Ọláberinjọ has seen: clean and exact, as if drawn with a fine instrument.

Two small Egun masquerades – PÀRÀKÁ MÉJÌ – stand to his left, motionless and masked. They are silent when Ọláberinjọ enters. One turns its masked face toward the door. The other does not.

His left hand rests on a vessel of akika. His head bears the faint marks of it: he has been applying it steadily, over time. This is not a ceremony. It is an ongoing practice.

He looks up when Ọláberinjọ enters.

He shows no surprise. There is no version of this moment in which he would show surprise.

The first pàràkà speaks. Short. Clipped. The compressed authority of the ancestral voice:

PÀRÀKÁ KINNÍ

(the speech of Egungun
– terse, final)

Ẹnu awo.

Oníkàámògún does not look at the pàràkà. He looks at Ọláberinjọ.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN

(in Yoruba)

Ẹnu awo ni ìbà òun àṣẹ wa

[SUBTITLE: The mouth of the diviner is where reverence originates. The mouth of the diviner is where command originates.]

Not a greeting. An orientation. He is telling Ọláberinjọ what kind of scene this is: a divination. Everything that follows is a divination.

INT. THE 17TH COMPOUND, INNER CHAMBER – CONTINUOUS

Oníkàámògún clears the divination tray and begins to cast for Ọláberinjọ – using the cobra's head to draw marks directly rather than casting palm nuts. Each mark pulled from the powder with precise, unhurried strokes.

The marks that emerge: Ìká Méjì. The doubled Ìká configuration.

He looks at the marks for a long time. Then:

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN

You came with a question. Not your question – a civilization's question. How do we use the arts to study the sciences? How do we use the sciences to study the arts?

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

Yes.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN

The Odu has already answered. It answered before you were born. The answer is in the reading itself – not in what I tell you, but in what the marks are.

(pointing to the Ìká Méjì configuration)

Look at these marks. What are they?

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

The Ìká Méjì configuration. Binary notation. Eight marks – four pairs. Each mark: present or absent, open or closed. One of the 256 possible Odu states.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN

Where did the marks come from?

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

From the cobra's head, drawn through the powder.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN

Where did the tradition of using the cobra's head come from?

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

(pause)

I don't know the exact origin.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN

From the observation of cobra movement in dust. The original Babalawo who first used this tool was observing the snake's path through sand and recognized in that path the beginning of the mark system. Natural

observation – geometric observation –
symbolic encoding – mathematical
system. All one gesture. Art and
science, inseparable from the first
moment.

(pointing to the
marks)

These marks are simultaneously: a poem
– the Ìká Méjì ese is among the most
beautiful in the Odu corpus. A binary
code – the foundation of computation.
A medical protocol – specific
prescriptions for specific conditions.
An astronomical record – Ìká Méjì
appears at a specific celestial
configuration that repeats on a
seventeen-year cycle. A governance
model. A game.

OLÁBERINJO

(quietly)

They were never separated.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN

They were never separated. The Odu was
always all of these things
simultaneously. The separation is the
poverty of perception. And like all
poverty of perception, it is a
cognitive state – not a material
reality. Alákàrà has the akara. The
market is full. The problem is not
shortage.

(beat)

The Babalawo who divines and the
mathematician who computes and the
poet who sings and the engineer who
builds – in the beginning, these were
the same person. They can be again.

The second pàràká speaks. It says: Ìká. Then again: Ìká. The third iteration has a different quality – lower, settled, as if the word has found its place in the earth. An Egungun says a word three times until the word becomes a reality.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN

The pàràká knows Ìká. Ká – to master. To know a thing so completely that the thing and the knower are no longer distinguishable. The pàràká does this with its very body – it becomes what it embodies. The masquerade is not wearing the ancestor. It is the ancestor. We are trying to do this with knowledge.

(standing; moving to
bring the board)

Understanding is not mastery. Mastery is demonstrated. Are you ready for the game?

INT. THE 17TH COMPOUND, INNER CHAMBER – CONTINUOUS

Oníkàámògún brings the Ayò Ọlọ́pọ́nfá board – the 16-pot board, the Ifa Computer. He sets it between them on a low table. In this space, with this man, the board has a different weight than when Ọláberinjọ saw it at House Eleven.

The two pàràká shift their stance. The masked faces turn toward the board. They are paying attention.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN

In regular Ayo: you take seeds from one pit, distribute them into subsequent pits, capture when you create specific configurations. The goal is to end with the most seeds. You play your side of the board.

(touching the 16-pot
board)

In Oníkàà – the chambered Ayo – the rule is different in one way that changes everything. You play the whole board. Either player can move seeds from any pit – yours or your opponent's – as long as you understand why you are moving them. The constraint is not whose pit it is. The constraint is whether the move serves the board's integration.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

How do you win?

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN

The winner is the one who, when the board reaches its final state, holds the deepest understanding of why every seed is where it is. The board judges it. Watch.

He distributes seeds for the starting position. The distribution is specific, not symmetrical – each pit begins with a quantity that corresponds to the complexity of its Odu.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN (CONT'D)

Begin.

--- THE GAME ---

OPENING MOVES: Oníkàámògún takes seeds from the pit corresponding to House One – Ogbe, first light – and distributes them forward along the board. Eight seeds, eight pots. From light toward contact.

Ọláberinjọ responds: seeds from Ose – House Fifteen, his crisis house – distributed forward, looping back toward the beginning. From abundance back toward first principles. A loop.

MIDDLE GAME: They play in silence. The game breathes differently from regular Ayo – slower inhalation, held breath before each move, slow exhalation as seeds move.

Ọláberinjọ is playing analytically at first – reading pot by pot, projecting forward, calculating. This is how he played Ayo before the journey. He is good at this.

But the board resists pure analysis. When he plays a move that serves only his row, the board's pattern becomes less coherent – he can feel it, the way a poorly argued sentence makes a paragraph fall apart. The board has a quality of rightness or wrongness not reducible to count-advantage.

THE CRISIS MOVE: Ọláberinjọ plays aggressively from the Okanran pit – House Eight – creating a position where he can capture from three of Oníkàámògún's pots on the next turn. Maximum capture. Standard Ayo logic applied to Oníkàà.

Oníkàámògún looks at the board. He makes a single move – takes two seeds from the central channel and distributes them across four pots along the board's center.

Ọláberinjọ's capture opportunity collapses. And the board's overall pattern – all sixteen pots – becomes more coherent. He can feel it. It is better. But he is losing.

THE STILLNESS: Ọláberinjọ stops. He does not make a move. He puts his hands in his lap.

He looks at the board the way he looked at the river in House Fifteen, all night. Not calculating. Looking.

Sixteen pots. He has been inside each one. The pits of Ìlú-Ìlù and Otura – sound-science and sky-science – are mathematically adjacent in the game's current state, even though they are spatially separated on the board. The drummer who encoded the orbital calculation. He made this connection then but didn't carry it forward.

He sees: the pits of Oturupon and Odi feeding each other – archaeology of knowledge and the science of hidden processes. You cannot recover what was buried without understanding what the burial process was.

He sees the whole cloth.

Not as a thought. As a perception. The way you see a face – not by analyzing the nose then the eyes then the mouth, but all at once as a face.

CLOSING MOVES: His first move from this new perception – seeds from Ogunda, the path-maker, distributed across five non-adjacent pots: Ogbe, Irosun, Okanran, Irete, Ofun. Five connections at once. The path-maker feeds the first principle, feeds the flow, feeds the decisive moment, feeds deep time, feeds completion. He can see these five are always in conversation.

A seed appears in the central channel. Spontaneously. He did not direct it there. The board put it there.

Oníkàámògún's eyes move to the channel. He makes a sound – not words, a sound of recognition. He has seen this happen before. Not many times.

They play four more moves each. Each move by Ọláberinjọ is a synthesis – not a calculation. He is not thinking; he is knowing.

FINAL MOVE: Ọláberinjọ takes seeds from the Ìká pit – House Eleven, where the weave is the answer – and distributes them in a spiral that touches every remaining pot on the board. One seed each. The board equalizes. No pit dominant, no pit empty. Every domain acknowledged simultaneously.

The central channel fills. Seven seeds, accumulated over the game, visibly complete.

The board is still.

Oníkàámògún looks at it for a long moment. He looks at Ọláberinjọ.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN

(in Yoruba)

Ọ̀ta ló máa jẹ Oníìká.

[SUBTITLE: It is the winner who will
be crowned as king of Ìká.]

No crown ceremony. No title conferred. No audience. The two pàràká stand absolutely still.

The crowning is the understanding. It happened during the game. The words confirm what has already occurred.

Ọláberinjọ does not feel victorious. He feels – for the first time since leaving the Institute – exactly the right size.

INT. THE 17TH COMPOUND, INNER CHAMBER – CONTINUOUS

Oníkàámògún puts the board away – each pit closed carefully, seeds counted back to starting positions, the central channel cleared. He does this with the same unhurried attention he gives everything. Ọláberinjọ watches.

When the board is stored, Oníkàámògún sits back. He picks up the divination tray – not to cast, but to look at the Ìká Méjì marks still there from the earlier reading.

He speaks to the marks. Not to Ọláberinjọ. He is speaking to the Odu.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN

(in Yoruba)

Ààke ní ń'bagi sá.

[SUBTITLE: It is the axe that hits a tree and runs back.]

The second pàràká affirms it in the ancestral voice: Ààke. The word lands like the thing itself.

This is not metaphor. This is the Ẹnu Awo – the diviner's mouth as instrument. What is spoken here has the force of an axe. What is named here moves.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN (CONT'D)

Ẹbọ gbà.

[SUBTITLE: The sacrifice was received.]

He does not name what the sacrifice was. Ọláberinjọ knows.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN (CONT'D)

Ogun là á. Èni tó là ọ̀nà – kì í jẹ olùrìn. Ó jẹ ọ̀nà. Èsẹ̀ rẹ̀ n dúrọ de àwọn tó n bọ̀.

[SUBTITLE: Ogun opened it. The one who clears a path – is not a traveler. He is the path. Your foot stands waiting for those who come.]

The four blessings – not prayers. Pronouncements. Ènu Awo. The diviner's mouth as command.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN (CONT'D)

Ajé wà. Ajé n' bọ̀. Báwo bá ní a làjé, a sì máa lájé.

[SUBTITLE: Wealth is here. Wealth is coming. However we shall have wealth, we shall have it.]

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN (CONT'D)

Ìyàwó wà.

[SUBTITLE: Partnership is here.]

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN (CONT'D)

Ọmọ wà.

[SUBTITLE: Continuity is here.]

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN (CONT'D)

Ìrẹ gbogbo wà.

[SUBTITLE: All good things are here.]

Silence. The two pàràkà are absolutely still. The ancestral witnesses have heard.

The Ènu Awo is complete. What was spoken will move.

CUT TO:

INT. THE 17TH COMPOUND / INT. INSTITUTE OF IFA STUDIES – DAY (TRANSITION)

The compound at the 17th house begins, very slowly, to change. Not dramatically. The light quality shifts. The texture of the walls – ancient stone – becomes faintly translucent. Through the stone, another room. The same room. The same configuration of objects. But connected to something else now.

The camera pulls back. The compound expands. We are in the Institute of Ifa Studies.

INT. INSTITUTE OF IFA STUDIES, VARIOUS SPACES – DAY (FUTURE)

Not a dramatic reveal. A gradual recognition.

A BABALAWO-ENGINEER at a workstation shaped like an Ifa divination tray – circular, the 256 Odu configurations as selectable parameters in a computational model. She is working on a structural problem for a building in Lagos. The Ogunda principle – paths that work with the land's biological memory – deployed as the foundation calculation.

A DRUM ENSEMBLE – Ìlú-Ìlù performers – recording new Èdè Ìlú sequences in collaboration with an INFORMATION SCIENTIST encoding a communication protocol in drum language. More efficient than binary – Yoruba drum language operates in four-state notation, not two-state. The rhythm is the protocol.

WEAVERS at digital looms – programmed with Odu matrices; the resulting àkà cloth is both a work of art and a functional diagnostic tool. The geometric pattern encodes the patient's Odu at time of production. The cloth is worn. The cloth is the medical record.

Ayò Ọlọ́pọ́nfá boards in every teaching space – the game played not as recreation but as training method. Every person who works here has learned to read the whole board.

Ọláberinjọ, older now, presenting to a much larger gathering. The question he came with – "How do we use the arts to study the sciences?" – is now a demonstrated method, with working applications, with a sixteen-house curriculum that students have been walking for a generation.

EXT. MARKET – DAY (PRESENT / FUTURE – AMBIGUOUS)

A market. A seller standing with something perfect. A busy market. No buyers.

Then: a buyer. Then another. Then the market flows toward her as a matter of course.

ALÁKÀRÀ – or her inheritor, her echo – does not look surprised. She looks exactly like someone who always knew the akara was right.

DISSOLVE TO:

EXT./INT. VARIOUS – THE CLOSING POEM

The same voice. The same Yoruba. The same sixteen lines. English subtitles appearing more slowly now – the audience has been inside this language for the full film; they are reading it differently.

Each image has been earned.

VOICE (V.O.)

Mo de Òde Ìká –

[SUBTITLE: I arrive at the Frontier of Ìká –]

Ọláberinjọ walking the road from Ofun toward the convergence point. We are arriving – and this time we know what we are arriving at.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Òde Ìkà – Òde Àká – Òde Ònkà –

[SUBTITLE: The Frontier of Cruelty – the Frontier of the Woven Thread – the Frontier of Counting –]

Three quick shots – we have been inside all three. We know the weight of each name now.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Níbití orúkọ wọn rí kakaka –

[SUBTITLE: Where their names are
many-layered and intricate –]

All 32 characters of this world – the ones we have met,
the ones we have heard of, the ones who exist at the edges
of the story. Their names layered, complex, earned.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Tí ọba wọn ní'gbé ní káà –

[SUBTITLE: Where their king dwells
within the innermost chamber –]

Oníkàámògún in his compound. We see his face clearly now
for the first time since the film began. Not hidden.
Known.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Tí o ní'dáfá pẹ̀lú orí ọkà –

[SUBTITLE: Who casts divination with
the head of the cobra snake –]

The cobra's head tracing marks in powder. Precise and
ancient and alive.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Tí ìbakà talákáa léjìkà –

[SUBTITLE: Where the donkey struck the
man named Lákáa upon the shoulder –]

The donkey and Lákáa. Still, quiet, irreversible. The
cobra at the tree root. The image carries the full weight
of the journey.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Àkàakà ìgbasà ló jẹ́ ará Òde Ìkà –

[SUBTITLE: The ones that spun the
thread continuously in the ìgbasà tree
are the people of Òde Ìkà –]

The thread-spinners at the àgbasà tree, their hands never stopping. Scientists and artists, the same hands.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Lọba ọba wọn, Oníkàámògún, ń'tayò
Oníkàà –

[SUBTITLE: Their paramount king,
Oníkàámògún, plays the chambered-Ayo
Game –]

The Ayò Ọlọ'pọ'nfá board. Sixteen pots. Seeds moving. The central channel holding its seven seeds.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Ọ'ta ló máa jẹ Oníìká –

[SUBTITLE: It is the winner who will
be crowned as king of Ìká –]

Ọláberinjọ. The winner. Not triumphant. The right size.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Tí o maaaa jayé ọba ní kàà –

[SUBTITLE: Yet he is the one who will
always thrive and reign as king within
the chamber –]

Oníkàámògún thriving and reigning. Not a king of territory. A king of mastery.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Òde Ìká níbití wọn tí n'ṣe aṣọ àká –

[SUBTITLE: Òde Ìká, where they have
long been weaving the àká cloth –]

The weavers of House Eleven. The Babalawo-engineers of the future. The same hands, different time.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Tí èbìtì kakaka ń'pa ìgbín kakaka –

[SUBTITLE: Where the strong trap kills
the strong snail –]

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Nítorì èbìtì tí ò gbójú kòlè pàgbín
kakaka –

[SUBTITLE: Because a trap that is not
strong cannot kill the strong snail –]

Ọláberinjọ at the river in House Fifteen. The whole
journey, compressed to one image.

VOICE (V.O.) (CONT'D)

Nílú Òde Ìká tí wọn tí n'se aṣọ àká –

[SUBTITLE: In the city of Òde Ìká,
where they have long been weaving the
àká cloth.]

FINAL IMAGE: A weaver – not one specific weaver from one
specific house, or all of them at once. Her hands moving.
The àká cloth emerging from the loom. The pattern
building. The camera holds on the cloth as it grows, the
Odu marks of Ìká Méjì forming in the weave – the doubled
mark, the system seeing itself. The pattern glows,
faintly, with the light of the 17th house.

The loom continues. The pattern will continue beyond the
frame.

FADE TO BLACK.

– END OF ACT THREE –

ACT FOUR – ÌPADÀBỌ̀ (THE RETURN)

Concluding Part One / Series One

[ÒDÈÌKÁ – Part One of Sixteen]

EXT. ÒDÈÌKÁ – CITY WALLS – DAWN

A different dawn from the one that opened this story. The same walls. The same stone. The same àká cloth patterns pressed into the masonry. But the light falls differently now – not the dramatic spill of Act One, not the searching arc of the journey, but a steady, earned illumination. Warm. Patient. Not yet full.

A muezzin of sorts – but it is not a voice calling. It is the sound of looms beginning. One. Two. A dozen. The city's morning prayer is the sound of work resuming.

We move through the city in a single, unbroken drift-shot – a gentle, unhurried camera that has earned the right to wander. The 16 Houses, glimpsed as we pass.

HOUSE ONE (OGBE): The solar observatory dome is open. Two apprentices check the morning readings. One writes in chalk on a slate the color of midnight. The other sketches in àká thread the exact pattern. Science and art. Same hand.

HOUSE THREE (IWORI): Ìyá Akáogbọ̀n moves slowly through her corridor of mirrors. She pauses at one. Looks. Nods – not at her own reflection, but at something she sees behind it. She is satisfied.

HOUSE SIX (OWONRIN): Ìlú-Ìlù is already alive – the drum city never truly sleeps. But the morning rhythm is different from the night rhythm. Slower. A conversation, not a proclamation.

HOUSE ELEVEN (ÌKÁ): The Ifa Art compound – the weavers are already at the àká cloth. The pattern from last night has

been slept on and resumed. The Ayò Ọlọ'pọ'nfá board sits at the center of the compound, its sixteen pots clean, seeds rearranged to starting position. Ready for the next game.

HOUSE FIFTEEN (OSE): Ọláberinjọ's river, seen in first proper daylight. The water holds the light differently. The àkàlàmbò bird – silent now. Its work last night was significant. It rests.

HOUSE SIXTEEN (OFUN): The threshold gate stands open. No one guarding it. No one needed.

We arrive finally at the center: the compound where the Ayo game was played. The board is still there. The seeds remain in the position they reached at game's end – the spiral distribution from the Ìká pit, the central channel full. No one has moved them.

Oníkàámògún sits nearby. Still in his àká cloth. He has not slept. He is not tired. He is computing something – not on paper, not on a tray. In his chest.

CUT TO:

INT. GREAT HALL OF ÒDÈÌKÁ – MORNING

The hall fills. Every character we have met across the sixteen houses – the scholars, the drum-speakers, the weavers, the sculptors, the astronomers, the botanists, the children who asked good questions in House Nine, the old woman who recognized the map in House Five. They come not because they were summoned, but because they felt the shift in the air and followed it.

Ọláberinjọ stands to one side, still in the traveling clothes she arrived in. She is the only one who does not belong by history. She belongs by journey.

Oníkàámògún stands – not at the throne at the chamber's center, but at the edge of the hall, near the door that opens to the outside. He faces both the room and the frontier.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN

(in Yoruba, carrying)

Mo fẹ́ sọ ọ̀kan soṣo nńkan.

[SUBTITLE: I wish to say one single thing.]

The room stills. Even the children.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN (CONT'D)

Ìjà tí ó n'pa wa ní òde – kì í ẹ ịjà ogun. Kì í ẹ ịjà owó. Kì í ẹ ịjà ilẹ̀. Ìjà yì nì: a máa n kọ ẹ̀kọ́ ní èdè elédè, pẹ̀lú àṣà aláṣà. A jẹ ọlọ̀gbẹ̀rì tí ò nímọ̀ tó péye ní èdè àbínibí rẹ, tí wá n'jẹ egungun bi alákarà Òde Ìkà.

[SUBTITLE: The war that is killing us outside – it is not a war of armies. Not a war of money. Not a war of land. The war is this: we learn in a foreign language and using a foreign culture We have become ọlọ̀gbẹ̀rì, who does not have solid knowledge in their mother tongue and thus suffers in the misdt of plenty like the akara seller in Ode Ika]

A long silence. The scholars recognize this word – ọ̀gbẹ̀rì – in their own work. In their own lives. The drummer looks at his youngest apprentice. The apprentice looks at the floor. Knows.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN (CONT'D)

Ìdáhùn kì í ẹ ìwé. Kì í ẹ òfin. Ìdáhùn nì ilé-ẹ̀kọ́ àti ìmọ̀ tí ó wá láti inú Ifá, ìmọ̀ tí a rán pọ̀, ìmọ̀ tí ó bá ìmọ̀ pàdé. Àwọn ìmọ̀ tí ó bárawọ̀n sọ̀rọ̀ ní Èdè Ọ̀pẹ̀ (Èdè Ifá).

[SUBTITLE: The answer is not a text. Not a law. The answer is a school and knowledge that comes from Ifa,

knowledge that is woven together. A school where knowledge does not travel to another place alone – knowledge that meets knowledge. Knowledge that talks to one another in Ọ̀pẹ̀ Language, the very ancient Language of Ifa (IfaLang).]

He turns to the hall. Gestures broadly – not at the walls but at the people. At what they each carry.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN (CONT'D)

Ilé mẹ́rìndínlógún. È̀kọ́
mẹ́rìndínlógún. Kò sí ọ̀kan tí ó ga ju
ìkejì. Kò sí ọ̀kan tí ó kéré ju ìkejì.
Gbogbo wọn jẹ́ ọ̀ba ara laye ara wọn.
Gbogbo wọn jẹ́ ẹ̀kọ́ funra wọn.
Bẹ́ẹ̀ ni Ìká Méjì ẹ̀ ní sọ.

[SUBTITLE: Sixteen houses. Sixteen disciplines. Not one greater than another. Not one lesser than another. Each is king to itself. Each is student to itself. So says Ìká Méjì.]

ÌYÁLÓDE ŞÀNGỌ̀ÈKÒ, the market queen from the Alákàrà quarter, steps forward. She is not a scholar. She is the woman who trades in the market that everyone passes through without stopping. She is the embodiment of the Ọ̀gbẹ̀rì (the 'uninformed') problem.

ÌYÁLÓDE ŞÀNGỌ̀ÈKÒ

(direct, market voice)

Ọ̀ba, àwa olójà – ẹ̀ ẹ̀ ní kí a mọ̀ ìmọ̀
àwọn ọ̀mọ̀wé?

[SUBTITLE: King, we market-people – should we learn scholars' knowledge?]

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN

Rárá. Àwọn ọ̀mọ̀wé ní a fẹ́ kí wọn mọ̀
ìmọ̀ olójà.

[SUBTITLE: No. We want the scholars to learn the knowledge of the market-people.]

A beat of surprise. Then – across the hall – something releases. Laughter that is also relief. The market queen stands taller. The scholars look at each other: we have work to do.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN (CONT'D)

(quietly, to the whole room)

Ká bè`rẹ`.

[SUBTITLE: Let us begin.]

CUT TO:

INT. HOUSE ELEVEN – ÌKÁ COMPOUND – LATE MORNING

Ọláberinjọ and Oníkàámògún, alone in the Ifa Art compound. The àká cloth, the Ayo board, the art-science instruments all around them. She is packing nothing – she arrived with almost nothing. But she is clearly preparing to leave.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

(in Yoruba, carefully)

Mo gbọdọ` padà.

[SUBTITLE: I must return.]

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN

Padà sí ibo?

[SUBTITLE: Return to where?]

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

Sí ibití mo bè`rẹ`. Ilé-ẹ̀kọ́ náà.
Àwọn ọmọ ẹgbẹ́ mi. Àwọn ọmọ tí ọ̀nà
ẹ̀kọ́ wọn kò dánmọrán tó. Mo mọ` ohun
tí mo ní lati ẹ bá yíí.

[SUBTITLE: To where I started. That institute. My colleagues. The students whose path of learning is not yet resolved. I know now what I have to do now.]

Oníkàámògún studies her. He is not testing her answer. He already knew what she would say. He is measuring whether she knows why she is saying it.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN

Kí ni ìmọ̀ tí o mú padà?

[SUBTITLE: What knowledge do you carry back?]

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

(a long pause – she is assembling something true)

Pé ohun tí a n pè ní ìmọ̀ ìjìnlè àti ohun tí a n pè ní ẹ̀kọ́ iṣẹ́ ọ̀nà kò yàtọ̀ rárá. Pé olùkọ̀ tí ó pín wọn sọtọ̀ ní láti ẹ̀ àtúnṣe. Pé ọ̀mọ́ tí n kọ́já kọ́já – kótodé – kì í ẹ̀ aláḱànú. Kò sí ibi tí ó tó pé kí a gbé dúró níbẹ̀.

[SUBTITLE: That what we call knowledge and what we call art were never separate. That a teacher who splits them apart needs correct this siloed approach.]

Oníkàámògún reaches beside the Ayo board. He lifts something small: a single ayò seed – one of the game seeds. He holds it out to Ọláberinjọ. She takes it.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN

Irúgbìn kan. Bẹ̀rẹ̀ pẹ̀lú rẹ̀. Ẹ̀ni tí yòò mọ́ ohun tí ó wa ní nínú ohun kékeré yìí – yòò mọ́ ohun mẹ́rìndínlógún.

[SUBTITLE: One seed. Begin with it.
The person who truly understands what
is inside this small thing – will
understand sixteen things.]

She closes her fingers around it. Nods. A student who has
finally found the right school.

ONÍKÀÁMÒGÚN (CONT'D)

(a half-smile)

Ẹnu Awo.

[SUBTITLE: The mouth of the mystery.]

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

(completing it,
quietly)

Àáke ní ń'bagi sá.

[SUBTITLE: It is the axe that hits a
tree and runs back.]

CUT TO:

EXT. GREAT GATE OF ỌDÈÌKÁ – MIDDAY

The city's great gate. The threshold. The place where the
frontier begins – or ends, depending on which direction
you are traveling.

Ọláberinjọ walks toward it alone. Behind her – not
following, but present – figures from each of the sixteen
houses. They do not form a procession. They have simply
all happened to be near the gate at this hour. The way a
city is always watching its travelers.

She pauses at the threshold. Turns once. Looks back at
what she is leaving. She cannot see all sixteen houses
from here. She does not need to. She carries the map.

The drummer of House Six raises one hand. A single note
– the dùndún calls a name in Yoruba drum language. Not her
name. Her title. The title the city is giving her as she
departs. There is no English subtitle for drum language.

The audience hears it directly.

She turns and walks through the gate.

SLOW MOTION: the moment she crosses the threshold. Her feet on the stone of the city; then her feet on the earth of the frontier. The precise line. This is the same gesture as the opening of the film – reversed. Then, she was arriving. Now she is departing.

The gate does not close behind her.

It stays open.

It will stay open.

CUT TO:

INT. INSTITUTE OF IFA STUDIES – LECTURE HALL – DAY

Hard cut. Modern. Fluorescent. The hum of air conditioning. Plastic chairs. A projector screen showing a PowerPoint slide. The present day.

The Institute of Ifa Studies – the frame device of Act One has been waiting here. The same space Ọláberinjọ stood in at the very beginning, presenting her early tentative research to skeptical colleagues.

But the hall is different now. Filled. Not with skeptical colleagues but with students – young, impatient, carrying the particular restlessness of people who have been taught that learning is supposed to hurt. They are Ọlọ̀gbẹ̀rì by design, by a system that has taught them to cram formulas and principles instead of seeking to understand as an interconnected system.

Ọláberinjọ stands at the front. She looks exactly as she did when she left – same clothes, same traveling worn quality – but her posture is different. She has been somewhere.

She looks at the PowerPoint slide. It shows the title of her talk: "Arts and Sciences in Odu Ifa: A Comparative

Framework." A good academic title. Correct. Sufficient. Bloodless.

She clicks the slide off. The screen goes white.

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

(in Yoruba, then
English – her first
and last code-switch)

Ẹ jẹ́ kí a bèrẹ̀ pẹ̀lú eré kan.

[SUBTITLE: Let us begin with a game.]

She opens her laptop. On the projected screen: the Ayò Ọlọ́pọ́nfá interface loads. The sixteen-pot board. The seeds. The central channel. A few students lean forward. Some exchange looks. This is not what they expected.

STUDENT – FRONT ROW

(skeptical, in
English)

Is this... a game?

ỌLÁBERINJỌ

(in Yoruba)

Àwòrán àgbáyé. Kì í ẹ̀ eré lásán,
ẹ̀rọ́fá ayárabíáṣá nì. Ẹ jẹ́ n ṣàlàyé.

[SUBTITLE: A world-model. Not merely a
game. The Ifa Computer. Let me
explain.]

She begins. And for the first time in the film, we sense that a teacher is teaching from inside the knowledge – not above it, not outside it, not passing through it – but dwelling there.

MONTAGE – THE SEMESTER:

The Ayò Ọlọ́pọ́nfá board as physics lesson – seeds as particles, pots as orbital positions. Students arguing over the central channel.

The Ìlú-Ìlù drum platform open on the screen – students listening to the Èdè Ìlú (drum language) as a data-compression lecture. The student from the front row is suddenly intensely interested.

The Ifa Art platform – a student's face close to the screen, tracing an Odu mark. Then, off-screen, the sound of her sketching the same mark into a geometry notebook.

A student in the hall who has never moved before – stands up to demonstrate something at the board. He is not passing through anymore. He is stopping.

End montage. Late afternoon. The hall is clearing.

Ọláberinjọ is alone, packing up. She opens her palm. The ayo seed from Oníkàámògún. Still there. She places it on the table beside the laptop. A small, exact gesture.

CUT TO:

INT. INSTITUTE OF IFA STUDIES – ỌLÁBERINJỌ'S OFFICE – NIGHT

Her office. Night. The city outside is indistinct – lights, traffic, the hum of a world that has not yet heard what she learned. Or has heard it, and is still figuring out how to listen.

She is at her desk. Ifa texts around her – physical volumes, worn at the spines, many of them her own annotations. She has been in this room before. She has read these books before. They are different books now. Same pages. Different eyes.

She opens her laptop. The Ayò Ọlọ'pọ'nfá board is still running from the day's session – paused mid-game, a student's unfinished move. She looks at it. Sixteen pots. Sees the whole board.

She begins to write her research notes. We see the screen over her shoulder – the working title: "Ìká Méjì as Generative Matrix: Toward an Integrative Epistemology of Ifa Science-Arts."

She types. Pauses. Reaches for the volume of Odu texts on her right side. She is not looking for Ìkà Méjì anymore. She knows it now. She opens the book to a different section. Her fingers find the place as if by memory, though she has not read this passage since before her journey.

She reads. Something changes in her face. Not alarm. Recognition. The feeling of hearing a name you thought you had imagined.

She opens a fresh document. Types a title. We see it on the screen:

[OGBE MÉJÌ – THE FIRST LIGHT]

Below it, she types the opening verse – in Yoruba. The first line of the corpus of the first Odu. The Odu that is the origin of light itself. She does not know yet where this will take her. She knows that she has to go.

She pauses. Looks up from the screen. Out the window. The city at night. In the far distance – barely visible through the smog and the towers of glass and concrete – something. Not walls. Not stone. But a quality of permanence that belongs to something that has been standing for a very long time.

She turns back to the screen. Keeps writing.

The ayo seed sits on the desk beside the laptop. The camera drifts toward it – slow, deliberate, earning the close-up. The seed in full frame. Unremarkable. Brown. Exactly the size of the knowledge contained inside it.

Then – in the seed, we see it. Not magic. Not CGI spectacle. Something simpler: the faint marks of Ìkà Méjì etched naturally into the surface of the seed itself. The Odu's own marks. The pattern was always there.

HOLD on the seed.

FADE TO BLACK.

END OF PART ONE

SERIES ONE – ÌKÁ MÉJÌ COMPLETE

[SIXTEEN SERIES TOTAL]

— — —

Series 1: Ìká Méjì – Òdè-Ìká

The mastery at the frontier. The polymathic king. The Ọ̀gbẹ̀rì named
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The first light. The Odu of origin. A different question. A different
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— — —

ÒDÈ-ÌKÁ

Written by CENProject and Babalawo Ajetumobi Esubiyi
Obakolawole

Based on Odu Ifa Ìká Méjì

Ìká Méjì has spoken.

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